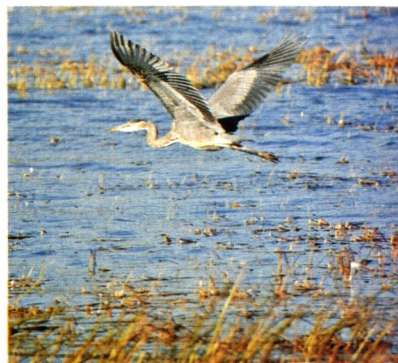




Save Wetlands

There are over 27,000 wetlands across the country that are rich in biodiversity, recharge groundwater, preserve flora and fauna and are a source of livelihood for those who live around them. But these are fast disappearing because of growing urbanisation and industrialisation. They also face the danger of heavy pollution from sewage and industrial units. There is an urgent need to save these water bodies. After making an inventory and assessing their condition, the state governments must take steps to restore them.



Drought Proofing

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Rise in global temperatures is expected to severely impact the rainfall pattern across India. Many areas that receive abundant rainfall may end up with droughts. This calls for a proactive government to work on drought-resistance crops and improve the productivity of land, water and human resources. What is needed are innovative measures to store water, develop better-quality seeds, apart from shoring up the capacities of the community to withstand natural adversities.

Bye Herbie

Most children remember Herbie, the indomitable Volkswagen Beetle that bounces back from the scrap yard. Well, now be prepared to say bye-bye to your Herbie. Most states are in the process of passing laws to retire old cars and trucks because of the high amount of pollution they generate. In fact, if you happen to transfer your four-year-old car from your home state to another, you may find your application for a new registration rejected. It's strange to know that your car would attain vintage status in just five years.



Miss that Plane

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It seems hard to tell those who have just begun enjoying the joys of a plane ride that the good times for air travel are over. Apart from rising costs, growing carbon emissions are worrying the world. In the US, air travel now accounts for 12 per cent of its carbon emissions. Globally, emissions from aircraft are expected to triple by mid-century leaving a dirty sky behind. Europe is already imposing a carbon tax on airlines to pay for clean-ups. Companies too are cutting down on unnecessary travels and with higher fuel prices, even holiday-goers are thinking twice.

Miracle Lamp

Solar lanterns are beginning to revolutionise rural home lighting just as the handpump brought water to the masses. Given the country's erratic power supply, the Government has embarked on a



major mission to encourage the use of solar lanterns. It wants to bring down the cost to less than the current average of Rs 2,000. Efforts are on to make them longer-

lasting and lighter. Researchers have suggested that developed countries donate lamps to poor countries and gain carbon credits in the process.

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Tele-Communing

This is just a fancy word used recently by futurist Alvin Toffler to describe the way out of the energy crisis facing the world. Instead of burning gallons of fuel either driving a car or flying in a plane, companies are increasingly encouraging their employees to use the phone to transact business. With phone calls becoming cheaper, even if you want to call Alaska from Antarctica, companies are already calculating the money they would save. Governments too are encouraging its employees to use the phone more often.

